

THE ILM FOUNDATION

Education Group Publication

ORGANIZATION UPDATE:

- Total number of **students sponsored**: 47 students (additional 6 students under one time aid)
- Total amount **collected in April**: 73,930 ₹
- Total amount **spent in April**: 47,770 ₹

OUR VISION

To uplift and transform the Muslim society from their educational poverty in the light of true knowledge which leads one back to Allah

FOOD FOR THOUGHT

"Those who spend (freely), whether in prosperity, or in adversity; who restrain anger, and pardon (all) men;- for Allah loves those who do good"

Surah Imran verse 134
Translation by Yusuf Ali

IN STRENGTH AND STRUGGLE

Mohammad Shazan is a class twelve student studying in Bangalore. His father has been severely ill for the past 15 years and is currently bedridden. His mother is a diabetic patient. Shazan and his younger brother, Farhan are the breadwinners of the family. Shazan puts up a vegetable stall and earns around 500 rupees daily. Farhan works in a mall. Unfettered by the overwhelming responsibilities, Shazan keeps up with his studies. He scored 83% in class X and 79% in class XI. He aims to become a CA in the future. The group helped Shazan submit a part of his school fee. Shazan is certainly one of the unsung heroes of our society and we pray for his success in this life and the next!

COPING WITH PANDEMICS: PSYCHOLOGICAL AND SPIRITUAL LESSONS FROM ISLAMIC HISTORY

Excerpts from the paper by Dr. Rania Awaad

Though the COVID-19 pandemic may seem novel, pandemics are not new to the greater human experience. This research highlights the psychological and spiritual coping mechanisms that early Muslims drew upon from Islamic teachings when they endured similar plagues. By discovering and adapting the psychological and spiritual coping mechanisms employed by early Muslims who endured some of the same trials we now face, we too can prosper despite the current atmosphere of uncertainty. We advise the reader to analyse the text carefully.

Issue One: Personal response

Countless stressors have been introduced into our lives. That much has been made clear. What remains unclear for many is the best way to deal with these stressors. The first thought that should cross our minds in moments of stress and anxiety are the words of our Lord, *"Allah does not burden a soul beyond its capacity."*

Confronting the fear of death and loss during pandemics

Upon examination of the psychosocial impacts of plague outbreaks on Muslim communities across the Mediterranean world during the medieval and early modern period, a natural question emerges regarding the responses and ways of coping during such adversity. Exploration of responses to outbreaks reveals two intertwined dimensions of the subject: attitudes and responses of Muslim communities as well as ethical and religious standpoints of Muslim scholars.

Attitudes of Muslims in the face of pandemics

In line with various wisdoms provided by Islamic tradition in understanding the plague, there was a spectrum of beliefs, explanations, attitudes, and ideas about the meaning and reasons behind the plague's emergence in Muslim communities. Additionally, there was a dynamic process of change over the centuries as plague recurred in shorter intervals, which brought even more diversity to the accumulation of Islamic discourse regarding epidemics.

In line with this, variation in responses to the epidemics was observed as well.

Inspired by prophetic instruction, many Damascene residents, who witnessed the outbreak, saw the pandemic as an opportunity to serve the community and initiate philanthropic projects.

The author cites examples to explain people's responses and concludes that there are essentially 2 types of responses: One that is a self-centered approach and the second is one of deeper meaning which recognizes opportunity with tribulation.

Coping with psychosocial impacts of pandemics

One significant indication of the severe psychosocial effects of the plague is that characteristics of the disease itself were described in such a dramatic sense which could be read as the intensity of fear and agony it created in the minds of its witnesses. For instance, the Byzantine-Ottoman chronicler Kritovoulos provided a striking description of the bubonic plague and its effect on the human body based on his own experience during an outbreak in Istanbul in 1467.

There was a strong sense of helplessness, lack of control, anxiety regarding the unknown nature of the situation, and uncertainty of what was coming next, especially during early periods when the plague experience was more severe and recent.

Coping with isolation

With the threat of transferring the virus to those we love barring us from much of our social interaction, feelings of loneliness and isolation may become overwhelming. While these feelings may be intensified due to the length of isolation further elongated with the assistance of modern technology, our Islamic tradition also offers supportive responses to this challenge.

While we hope that our isolation and loneliness is only a passing state, perhaps it is a unique opportunity to reconnect with God and focus on our devotion to Him. We have the chance to look at how we benefit from those around us and what harm we receive as well.

Issue Two: Communal response

For those who lived through plague in the Muslim world, responses came in two forms: actions and beliefs. One could respond positively with their actions, showing resilience and determination to support their community either through communal service for the ill, dead or, at the very least, through observing public health directions such as social isolation and quarantine.

Acts of communal service as a response to pandemics

Historically, we see examples of Muslims benefiting their communities either with their wealth or with their efforts during similar times of need. During plague outbreaks in Samarkand (439 H/1047 CE), Muslims increased their charitable work, stepped back to reflect and repent, spent more time reading the Qur'an, and collectively rid their city of unlawful instruments and intoxicants. Muslim communities were generally adherent to the practice of neither fleeing nor entering a plague-stricken land. There was a sense of shared responsibility to put the good of the community before the welfare of the individual.

If we cannot serve our communities through providing care for those in need, we should serve one another through encouragement and setting a good example.

Promoting balanced attitudes and ethical responses through religion

Our response to hardship is having ṣabr (patience) with what we are enduring and realizing the shukr (gratitude) we owe for the blessings we enjoy in our lives. For now, many of us are having to do without many activities of our daily life for which we do not realize we should be grateful. We now see the special importance our social connections serve in a way we would otherwise never have seen. We see how the most basic of daily securities can vanish in an instant. How many of us gave second thought to touching a door handle, standing within six feet of another person, or just breathing without a face covering? These are all but a few of the countless blessings our Lord has favored us with. Many of us might have never considered the bounty we enjoyed had He not removed it from us.

Conclusion

We must understand our duty to the general public, in the form of following public health ordinances and presenting appropriate public responses to our community, through encouraging appropriate perceptions of our situation and proper acts to maintain our psycho-spiritual health, and finally, to ourselves, that we monitor our own response to the atmosphere we find ourselves in.